



Fairy tales

By the 1800s, the fairy tale had become a prominent fixture in European culture for both children and adults. Magic was a major ingredient and some tales had a dark, strange occultism, too. Fairies, witches, transformative characters, spells, curses, and potions abounded. Many fairy tales were extensions of existing traditions of magical folklore, such as *Fortunatus*, a story about a purse that magically refills, which was circulating by the 1700s.

Magical tales, such as Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, with its enchanted potions and a deck of cards that come to life, thrived in an age influenced by Romanticism and its stress on freedom of the imagination. They offered an escape from the grimy reality of the Industrial Revolution and reflected the Victorian love of fairy tale art, part of a wider celebration in fiction of childhood innocence.

German fantasy writing was a huge influence, often derived from national folk history. The Brothers Grimm, leading folklore collectors, retold tales such as "Hansel and Gretel" and "Rumpelstiltskin," which respectively featured a witch and the magic art of spinning straw into gold. First published in 1812, these collected fairy tales became known as *Grimm's Fairy Tales* and were famously illustrated by Arthur Rackham in the 1900s. Other magical tales popular between the 1700s and early 1900s include the Middle Eastern *One Thousand and One Nights* and American author L. Frank Baum's *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz*, with good and evil witches, winged monkeys, and magic shoes.

"But the old woman was a wicked witch who was lying in wait there for children."

"HANSEL AND GRETEL," FROM GRIMM'S FAIRY TALES